EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 26 OCTOBER 2026

Paarl, Western Cape

In Paarl the people who die are asleep in shacks when a fire starts, in any year. A strong El Niño adds summer heat, not drought. The first job is a smoke alarm in every informal dwelling not yet covered, before December.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Cape Winelands District (inferred)	None published for South Africa	n/a here; global 6-month figure 239,000 ± 11,000	Shack fires (any year), summer heat Dec–Apr, mountain wildfire

12/12 recommendations checked. 0 confirmed outright, 8 corrected, 0 unverified, and 4 contraindicated (the four "Do not" cards). The 5 resident steps (added 26 October 2026) were checked separately: 1 confirmed, 4 corrected. The funding target is unchanged at R1.76 million (US$106,900); the ceiling was corrected to R2.4 million (US$145,700). Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review). It publishes no figure for South Africa, the Western Cape, or the Cape Winelands, and none was scaled down to Paarl. Heat is a real hazard here, but the record and the local studies carry it, not a borrowed number.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



33.73°S 18.97°E, South Africa · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Shack fires kill here every year, El Niño or not. El Niño adds summer heat to Paarl, not drought.
- **For you.** By 1 December, get a smoke alarm up (free if Fire & Rescue fits it), leave it up, and agree how everyone gets out at night.*
- **The money.** R630,000 floor, R1.76 million target, R2.4 million ceiling (US$38,300 / US$106,900 / US$145,700). Smoke alarms come first.
- **Do not.** Do not line shacks with cardboard or foam against heat. Cardboard-lined shacks spread fire faster.*

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT THIS PLACE IS, AND WHAT EL NIÑO DOES HERE — SCOPE

The request named "Paarl Cape Town". Paarl is not in the City of Cape Town. It lies about 60 km north-east of it and is governed by **Drakenstein Local Municipality**, in the Cape Winelands District. This briefing covers Paarl town, including Mbekweni, Paarl East, and the informal settlements. Some events in the record happened near Wellington (Newrest, Noordkamp). They are in Drakenstein and are cited as such.

The El Niño is strong. NOAA's index (ONI) was +2.16 for July to September 2026, and NOAA gives a better than 83% chance that it lasts through January to March 2027. But UCT's Climate System Analysis Group finds the El Niño–drought link "only valid for summer rainfall". Over the south-western Cape, El Niño years tend to be wetter, not drier. Paarl's dams fill in winter, and that season is over: on 14 October the Berg River Dam was 93% full. The South African Weather Service's October outlook flags heat, strongest in the interior and north-east. This is a national heat signal; a Western Cape outlook was not confirmed. So this briefing leads with fire and heat, and keeps water as a contingency.

FOR YOU, AS A RESIDENT — 5 STEPS

For a household in Paarl, this summer means a night fire that spreads in minutes, and hot days from December to April that are hardest on babies and older people. These steps work whether you live in a brick house in Paarl or Paarl East, or in a shack or backyard room in Mbekweni or Thembani; where a step is only for one of them, it says so. No role was given with the request, so this section is written for a resident. The ranked actions below are written for the municipality, the province, and their partners. These are the ones you can take yourself.

1 · Get a smoke alarm up before December, leave it up, and agree how everyone gets out at night *

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTIONS 1 AND 2

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
1 December 2026	None if Fire & Rescue fits it. Bought in bulk, the hardware is about R300–320 (US$18–19) an alarm, an estimate; we did not check shop prices	Everyone asleep in the home

At Silvertown in May 2023 the call came at 04:25, and three people from one family died in their sleep. In Wallacedene, Cape Town, alarms gave 11 real fire alerts and 4 rescues in a year, but many were taken down, so leave yours on the ceiling. Agree who wakes whom

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

and which way out. Shout the alarm and get everyone out first, and use a bucket only on a fire that has just started: in a full-scale test, fire went through 20 shacks in 4–5 minutes.*

2 · Before December, know who near you lives alone, is old, is bedridden, or has a baby, and agree who checks on them

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 3

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
1 December 2026	None	Infants, older people, and the sick on your street

In a shack area, give the names to your street committee; on a formal street, agree it with your neighbours. Across South Africa, deaths rose 6% on the hottest days, mostly among children under five and people over 64 (Scovronick 2018, not re-checked at source), and nobody in Drakenstein runs a heat-health plan yet.

3 · On a hot day, 32 °C forecast or a SAWS heatwave warning, check on those people, keep drinking water to hand, and have oral rehydration salts for small children*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM ACTION 3

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Every hot day, December 2026 to April 2027	None; ask your clinic for oral rehydration salts (ORS)	Babies, toddlers, older people, and anyone with a heart or lung condition

Do not wait for the 40 °C warning: in a Gauteng study most heat deaths came at a 31 °C maximum (SAMRC, June 2026). Keep a filled, lidded container of drinking water at home so no one has to queue at a tap in the afternoon heat, and move the person at risk to the coolest shaded place, because a tin shack can run 4–5 °C hotter than outdoors (Johannesburg, 8 dwellings measured). Paarl's record, 46.2 °C, came in March, so keep doing this into April.*

4 · Do not line walls or ceilings with cardboard, foam, or polystyrene to keep cool; use shade and open-through air instead*

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FROM DO-NOT 2

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Now, before the first hot spell	None for shade and ventilation; a reflective roof coating costs money (price not checked)	Your home and the homes next to it

This is mainly for shacks and backyard rooms. Stellenbosch University found cardboard-lined shacks spread fire faster than unlined ones; polystyrene was not tested, but untreated polystyrene burns. A reflective coating cut the daily maximum by up to 4.3 °C on test structures (Kimemia 2020), not yet in lived-in homes.

5 · Register or renew for the municipality's indigent support, and apply for any SASSA grant you qualify for, before the heat

CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 5

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
November–December 2026	None; data or a phone for the SRD application	Household income through the hot season

Drakenstein raised its indigent income thresholds by as much as 30% for 2026/27, and the Child Support Grant no longer counts as income, so households turned down before may now qualify (Paarl Post, 27 May 2026). The SRD grant of R370 (US$22) a month runs to 31 March 2027 and is applied for only online, at srd.sassa.gov.za; the Child Support Grant is R580 (US$35) per child a month. We did not check either grant's means test.

Only if you work on a farm in the grape harvest (December to March). This is not a new rule: the OHS Act already requires your employer to give water, shade, and rest in the heat. After seven or eight grape workers died at Kakamas in January 2023, Labour inspectors advised split shifts of 04:00–11:00 and 17:00–19:00 on hot days.

What to ask of the people in charge

- Ask **Drakenstein Fire & Rescue** whether your street or settlement already has smoke alarms from the provincial programme, and if not, when they will fit them (action 1).
- Ask the **Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre** whether it will act on a 32 °C forecast this summer, and whether Norsa Community Centre in Mbekweni will open as a cool room with water; phone Norsa before you go (action 3).

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet.

1. Fit a smoke alarm in every informal dwelling not yet covered, starting with Silvertown, Thembani, and Neder Park in Mbekweni, before December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Fire & Rescue, with the Western Cape Department of Local Government (Disaster Management) as funder	Coverage checked first; installed before 1 December 2026	About R960,000 (US$58,300), in two tranches of about R480,000 (US$29,100). Equipment only; an estimate	Deaths in night fires, while people sleep

At Silvertown, Mbekweni, in late May 2023, the call came at 04:25. Three members of one family died in their sleep. An alarm buys the minutes to get out.

First, find the gap. On 24 October 2024 the Western Cape's MEC Anton Bredell said 15,200 alarms had been installed province-wide since 2016. About 3,000 more were then in procurement for Drakenstein, Saldanha Bay, and Overstrand. Overstrand's share was handed over in August 2025, so Drakenstein's may be in already. Ask Drakenstein Fire & Rescue what is covered, then fund only the rest.

The unit cost is our estimate. No unit price is published. Overstrand bought 1,577 alarms with R500,000 (US$30,400), about R320 (US$19) each. Swartland's figures give about R280–290 (US$17–18). Fire crews installed them, so labour is not in the price. Use photoelectric, 10-year sealed alarms, and revisit homes after six months.

The evidence. In Wallacedene, Cape Town, 1,200 alarms were tracked for 12 months. They gave 11 real fire alerts and 4 rescues (*Int J Disaster Risk Science*, 2022, peer-reviewed). Many alarms were removed. The study has no count of lives saved.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: high. Wallacedene is an informal settlement in the same metro region. The weak points are removal and the unknown number of uncovered homes. An option to ask about: Lumkani's networked detectors with Hollard first-loss cover, at R88 (US$5.30) a month for up to R40,000 (US$2,400). It paid about R1.285 million (US$78,000) to 59 claimants in Masiphumelele in 2022. No evidence shows it operates in Drakenstein, so ask Lumkani first.

2. Slow the spread: clear refuse-filled lots and keep access lanes open at settlement edges in Mbekweni, Paarl East, and Wellington by 30 November

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Fire & Rescue, with Drakenstein Human Settlements; street committees run the first five minutes	**30 November 2026; then on every SAWS wind-warning day**	**Not costed (a lens estimate of R150,000–300,000, or US$9,100–18,200, in labour, unsourced)**	**Fire jumping from shack to shack before crews arrive**

Three parts. Clear lots full of refuse and keep gaps of about 3 m, or lanes a fire engine can use, where that can be done without moving anyone. On SAWS wind-warning days, pre-stage crews near the settlements. Street committees run a "first five minutes": raise the alarm and get people out first. Buckets are only for a fire that has just started.*

The evidence is engineering, not outcomes. Stellenbosch and Edinburgh modelling puts the critical gap at about 3 m, with a 6% chance of spread remaining at that distance. A back-analysis of a Masiphumelele fire gave 3.5 m. In a 2018 full-scale test, fire went through 20 dwellings in 4–5 minutes in a 15–25 km/h wind. No study shows that firebreaks cut deaths.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: good for the physics, which was studied in Western Cape settlements. The researchers say 3 m is often not achievable in practice. Do it only where it is.

3. Run a heat-health trigger from December to April at a forecast 32 °C, not 40 °C: a "who's inside" list, clinic calls, and a cool room in Mbekweni

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST

ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre, with Western Cape Health and the Department of Social Development (DSD)	Ready by 1 December 2026; runs to 30 April 2027	R150,000 (US$9,100) for the cool room and outreach; a judgment, not costed	Deaths of infants, older people, and the chronically ill on hot days

No Western Cape or Drakenstein heat-health plan was found. Only the national Heat Health Action Guidelines (2020) exist. So this fills a gap. Trigger it on a forecast maximum of 32 °C or more, or on a SAWS heatwave warning. Do not wait for the 40 °C "extremely high temperatures" advisory.

- **Street committees** keep a "who's inside" list of the elderly, infants, and the bedridden, each with a named neighbour.
- **Clinics** call chronic heart and lung patients and carers of under-5s, and stock oral rehydration salts.
- **A cool room with water** at Norsa Community Centre, Mathakutha St, Mbekweni (021 873 5636). It is a DSD feeding hub. Its listing dates from 2019 and says nothing on cooling or capacity, so phone first.

The evidence: across South Africa, deaths rose 6% on the hottest 1% of days, mostly among under-5s and those over 64 (Scovronick 2018). Cape Town shows a similar rise (Wichmann 2017). A SAMRC brief (June 2026) names under-5s and over-65s as most at risk above about 30 °C. Shacks ran 4–5 °C hotter than outdoors in Johannesburg (Naicker 2017). Paarl's record is 46.2 °C, in March 2010, so the season runs into autumn.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: Scovronick and Wichmann are South African, and Wichmann is Cape Town. Both were not re-checked at source. Naicker measured only 8 dwellings, so it is indicative. Ahmedabad's heat plan (Hess 2018) is often cited for lives saved. It is observational, from a much hotter Indian city: a transfer, not proof.

4. Enforce the heat duties farms already have during the grape harvest, December to March, and tell workers in Afrikaans and isiXhosa

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE · FOOD | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Department of Employment and Labour inspectors; Agri Western Cape and growers apply it	Before the harvest starts in December; on every SAWS heat day to March 2027	Inspectors' time and voice notes; not costed	Heat collapse and death in midday vineyard work

This is not a new rule. The OHS Act's section 8 general duty and the Environmental Regulations for Workplaces already cover heat. After Kakamas (Northern Cape, January 2023), where 7–8 grape workers died at about 41 °C, Labour inspectors advised split shifts: 04:00–11:00 and 17:00–19:00. Growers should provide water, shade, and rest, and apply those shifts on SAWS heat days. Women on Farms Project can send voice notes in Afrikaans and isiXhosa on workers' rights and how to report a farm.

Transferability: weak evidence. Kakamas is hotter and inland. No autopsies were done, the cause is disputed, and the section 31 inquiry has no published outcome. No study gives a death toll avoided by harvest heat rules. Women on Farms Project's reach was not verified.

5. Run an indigent registration and renewal drive, with SASSA grant days, in Mbekweni, Paarl East, the informal settlements, and on farms in November and December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · FOOD | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Municipality (indigent office), with SASSA	November–December 2026	Staff time only	Eligible households facing the heat and fire season without support they already qualify for

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Drakenstein has R215 million (US$13.1 million) for indigent support in 2026/27, and 16,550 households are registered. Thresholds rose by as much as 30%. Child support and foster care grants no longer count as income (Paarl Post, 27 May 2026). Many newly eligible households are not yet registered. No renewal deadline is published, so this is an outreach push on the existing register.

Add SASSA uptake on the same days. The SRD grant is R370 (US$22) a month until 31 March 2027, and it is online only, so bring phones and data. The Child Support Grant is R580 (US$35) per child a month from 1 April 2026.

Transferability: these are local instruments, so no transfer is needed. There is no evidence on deaths; this protects income. The SRD and Child Support Grant means tests were not checked. The economist's point: nothing else here moves money before the heat. The welfare rolls are the only pre-arranged finance.

6. Settle wildfire money and mutual aid before 1 December: who pays for aircraft after the first hour, and the district's 2026/27 budget

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Cape Winelands District Municipality, with Drakenstein Fire & Rescue and Drakenstein Disaster Management	**1 December 2026**	**No new money; a decision**	**Aircraft held back mid-fire because the budget has run out**

The province already pays for the first hour of aerial support. Agree now who pays after that. The district's R90 million (US$5.5 million) was its 2025/26 allocation (EWN, 21 November 2025); confirm the 2026/27 figure. Last season the province spent about R19 million (US$1.2 million) from 1 December 2025 to 11 January 2026, R16 million of it on aircraft. Premier Winde called the disaster budget "nearly depleted". On 22 January 2026 the provincial Cabinet *requested* a provincial disaster classification; a grant was not confirmed.

Drakenstein Disaster Management should keep its costing templates ready for the Municipal Disaster Response Grant. That grant pays only after a national classification.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: local precedent. The Paarl Mountain fire of 30 November–1 December 2024 (123 ha) was held by Drakenstein with the district, Swartland, Stellenbosch, the City of Cape Town, and aircraft.

7. Agree a fire-relief call-down line with Gift of the Givers, drawn when Drakenstein's disaster office asks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PHILANTHROPIST · FOOD · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre; Gift of the Givers delivers	Agreed by 1 December 2026; drawn after each fire	R450,000 (US$27,300), released on request; per-kit cost unpublished	Families left without documents, grant cards, and a way to cook after a fire

Aim it at the gaps public relief leaves: replacement documents and SASSA grant cards, cooking kits, and children's needs. Do not pre-buy food or mattresses. The municipality already hands out food parcels, blankets, and mattresses (2021, 2025). Stored food also spoils.

Gift of the Givers has responded in Drakenstein at least three times: Drommedaris (December 2021), Newrest (April 2025), and Thembani (20 December 2025). Each time it came after the fire. No pre-agreed line was found.

Transferability: local channel, proven three times. This placement reduces harm more than it averts deaths.

8. Keep water as a contingency: update the 2018 list of off-network Berg River farm households, and hold R200,000 only for restrictions

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre, with Western Cape Disaster Management	List updated before December; reserve held to 31 March 2027	R200,000 (US$12,100) reserve, released only if restrictions are imposed; a judgment figure	A repeat of 2018, when farm households off the piped network went without safe water

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

On 13 March 2018, at the province's request, Gift of the Givers brought bottled water to Hermon and Gouda. Those families were off the network the drought plan assumed. Update that list now. On 14 October 2026 the dams stood at Berg River 93%, Wemmershoek 85%, and Voëlvlei 58%. The Department of Water and Sanitation (Western Cape) reviews restrictions at its annual operating analysis meeting on 2 November 2026. That meeting is a review, not a guaranteed decision.

If no restrictions come by 31 March 2027, the reserve moves to the food-trigger reserve. Also check whether a February 2026 national drought classification covers Drakenstein; if it does, emergency procurement may already be open.

Transferability: local precedent. Restrictions are unlikely with the dams this full, so expect the money to roll over.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal. DMC = Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre. Drakenstein Mun. = other municipal departments (Human Settlements, the indigent office, water services). CWDM = Cape Winelands District Municipality. WC = Western Cape Government. DSD = Department of Social Development. DWS = Department of Water and Sanitation.

Action	Fire & Rescue	DMC	Drakenstein Mun.	CWDM	WC Disaster Mgmt	WC Health	DSD	Labour Dept	SASSA	DWS	Agri WC / growers	Gift of the Givers	Women on Farms	Street committees
1. Smoke alarms in uncovered dwellings	**A/R**	**C**			**R**									**C**
2. Lots cleared, lanes open, first five minutes	**A/R**	**C**	**R**											**R**
3. Heat-health trigger at 32 °C		**A/R**	**I**			**R**	**R**							**R**
4. Farmworker heat duties enforced						**I**		**A/R**			**R**		**R**	
5. Indigent and grant drive			**A/R**						**R**				**C**	**C**
6. Wildfire money and mutual aid	**R**	**R**		**A/R**	**C**									
7. Fire-relief call-down line		**A**	**C**						**C**			**R**		
8. Rural water contingency		**A/R**	**R**		**C**					**C**		**R**		

What the chart shows: the Drakenstein Disaster Management Centre is accountable for three rows, and Fire & Rescue for two. Street committees do the work in three rows; nothing in Mbekweni works without them. Rows 4, 5, and 6 need a decision or staff time, not money.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR

R630,000 (US$38,300)

TARGET

R1,760,000 (US$106,900)

CEILING

R2,400,000 (US$145,700)

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY

How many informal dwellings in Drakenstein still lack an alarm

Floor: alarms for the 1,500 densest dwellings, 1,500 × R320 = R480,000, plus 100 relief draws at an estimated R1,500 = R150,000. Total R630,000. **Target:** the sum of the four placements, R960,000 + R150,000 + R450,000 + R200,000 = R1,760,000. **Ceiling:** about 5,000 alarms, 5,000 × R320 = R1,600,000, plus the other placements, R800,000. Total R2,400,000. Five thousand is the crew limit before January; the province has averaged about 1,700 installs a year. The target did not move in verification. The ceiling was corrected from about R2.5 million to R2.4 million. Every unit price is an estimate.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Drakenstein Fire & Rescue	Action 1: smoke alarms for uncovered informal dwellings	R960,000 (US$58,300)	Top-up to the provincial Smoke Alarm Project, in two tranches; conditional on the uncovered count	~3,000 × ~R320, equipment only (Overstrand and Swartland divisions). Wallacedene: 11 alerts and 4 rescues per 1,200 alarms a year. No published cost per life	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Norsa Community Centre (DSD), through an NPO or municipal conduit	Action 3: cool room, water, and check-ins	R150,000 (US$9,100)	Matching grant	A judgment; not costed. No precedent for a cooling refuge there	UNVERIFIED
Gift of the Givers, on the Drakenstein DMC's request	Action 7: documents, grant cards, cooking kits, and children's needs after fires	R450,000 (US$27,300)	Call-down line, released on request	Per-kit cost unpublished. Three Drakenstein responses, 2021–2025	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Drakenstein DMC, pooled reserve	Action 8: water for off-network farm households	R200,000 (US$12,100)	Reserve, released only if DWS imposes restrictions	A judgment figure. Moves to the food-trigger reserve if unused by 31 March 2027	CONFIRMED AS A CONTINGENCY

Held outside the target: a R900,000 (US$54,600) food-trigger reserve. Release it when SAFEX May-2027 white maize futures pass about R5,000 a tonne, or when the first 2026/27 crop estimate (late February 2027) comes in well short of about 12 million tonnes of consumption. Spent now, it would duplicate DSD feeding. See the disagreement below.

Anticipatory finance was checked. No African Risk Capacity membership was found for South Africa. No South African Red Cross or IFRC early action protocol covers heat, drought, or fire here; Eswatini's drought protocol, activated on 9 September 2026, does not cover South Africa. No parametric cover was found.

The funder's one thing: every rand spent here so far arrived after the fire. A R320 alarm fitted before December is the cheapest life saved in Paarl. The food money should wait for the futures trigger.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Do not make drought, water restrictions, or tankering the headline El Niño action

CONTRAINDICATED

UCT's Climate System Analysis Group finds the El Niño–drought link "only valid for summer rainfall". Over the south-western Cape, El Niño correlates with more rain, not less. The winter rain season is over and the dams are high: Berg River 93% and Wemmershoek 85% on 14 October. A drought headline pulls money and attention from the fires that kill here.

Instead: put the effort into heat and fire. Watch the dams monthly, and keep water as a contingency (action 8).

Do not line shacks with cardboard, or add foam or polystyrene insulation, to keep them cool*

CONTRAINDICATED

Stellenbosch University found that shacks lined with cardboard are at higher risk of fire spread than those lined with nothing or with non-combustible material. Polystyrene was not tested directly. But untreated polystyrene burns, and fire already crosses 20 shacks in 4–5 minutes.

Instead: shade, ventilation, and a reflective cool-roof coating. On test structures, a cool roof cut the daily maximum by up to 4.3 °C (Kimemia 2020).

Do not warn only on 40 °C "extreme" days

CONTRAINDICATED

A SAMRC brief on Gauteng (30 June 2026) says: "Most deaths occur at lower heat thresholds than expected." Most deaths there came at a 31 °C maximum. It also warns of alert fatigue. Gauteng is inland highveld, so this shows the direction, not a Paarl threshold.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: trigger at a forecast 32 °C or a SAWS heatwave warning (action 3).

Do not open cooling centres people must drive to, or that work only with grid power

CONTRAINDICATED

People in Mbekweni and Paarl East walk. National load-shedding has been suspended since about May 2024, but local outages from faults and cable theft still happen. A centre that needs a car or the grid fails the people most at risk.

Instead: refuges within walking distance in Mbekweni and Paarl East that work without power: shade, water, and ventilation.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE — THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
2009	Week-long fire on Paarl Mountain	Not recorded	Not re-checked
Mar 2010	Paarl's heat record, 46.2 °C, as El Niño decayed	No heat-death count exists	Nothing on record
Aug 2013	Berg River floods	Not recorded	Nothing on record
Jan 2016	El Niño: record white maize prices; 2015–16 crop about 8.9 Mt	Food inflation 10.8% in 2016	The template for the food trigger in this briefing
Jan 2017	Farm fire on the Drakenstein slopes	137 evacuated from two farms	Nothing on record
Mar 2017	Shack fire, Nether Park, Mbekweni	1 dead	Nothing on record
2015–2018	Drought after dry 2016 and 2017 winters (weak La Niña and neutral, not El Niño). Level 6B restrictions, Feb 2018	Farm households off the network without safe water	Bottled water to Hermon and Gouda, 13 Mar 2018, by Gift of the Givers at the province's request

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Dec 2018	Paarl Mountain fire	About 500 ha	Nothing on record
Dec 2021	Shack fire, Neder Park, Mbekweni	About 100 shacks; about 200 destitute	Municipal parcels and help with SASSA documents; Gift of the Givers relief
Late May 2023	Shack fire, Silvertown, Mbekweni; call at 04:25	3 dead, 4 structures	Nothing on record
Jun 2023	Berg River floods	Not recorded	Nothing on record
Apr 2024	Fire in gale-force wind, Smartie Town	7 houses	Nothing on record
30 Nov–1 Dec 2024	Paarl Mountain fire, arson	123 ha	Held with district and neighbour crews and aircraft. Arsonist convicted 11 Feb 2025
Apr 2025	Shack fire, Newrest, Wellington (Drakenstein)	About 360 structures, 2 dead (first reports: about 200 and 1)	Joint relief by the municipality and Gift of the Givers
20 Dec 2025	Shack fire, Thembani, Mbekweni (about 14 more on 26 Dec)	About 40 dwellings	Gift of the Givers meals and water at the DMC's request
Dec 2025–Jan 2026	Western Cape wildfire season	Province spent about R19 million (US$1.2 million) in six weeks	Provincial disaster classification requested, 22 Jan 2026
May 2026	Floods in Drakenstein	More than 240 residents evacuated	Nothing on record
11 Oct 2026	Shack fire, Noordkamp (Bakka), Wellington area	4 dead: a mother, two sons, and a visiting 10-year-old	Alleged arson; police investigating. Single source

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The recurrence nobody has noticed: the dead here come from a hazard that ignores ENSO. Settlement fires kill in December and April in any year. The El Niño label should not pull money from fire prevention.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREED — RESOLVED

- **Forward-buy staples now** (food lens) versus **hold the food money** (philanthropist). The evidence supports holding, with a market trigger rather than a calendar date. September food inflation was 1.2% (Stats SA, released 21 October). White maize was R3,917 a tonne on 3 September 2026, and May-2027 futures were R4,198, about 7% higher. The 2025–26 crop was a record, with large stocks carried over. But the philanthropist's timing was wrong: the price shock shows in futures while the crop is failing, as in late 2015 and January 2016, not after the harvest. So the R900,000 (US$54,600) reserve is held outside the target and released on the futures or crop-estimate trigger.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No local record of heat deaths exists for Drakenstein, and nobody tracks daily all-cause deaths. This summer's heat toll will be invisible. It will be recorded as cardiac, respiratory, or diarrhoea in toddlers. Western Cape Health should fix a 2019–2025 all-cause baseline for Drakenstein for December to April, so that someone can tell whether this El Niño killed anyone in Paarl.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Scope.** The request named "Paarl Cape Town". It was built for Paarl town in Drakenstein Local Municipality, including Mbekweni, Paarl East, and the informal settlements, not for the City of Cape Town. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as the report records it: Cape Winelands District (inferred). Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); sub-city detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It names no figure for South Africa, and no figure was scaled down to Paarl. The historical record and South African studies carry the heat and fire hazards instead.
- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Four separate verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions and the exchange rate had their own verifier, which checked availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether each instrument already exists. Food and the funding envelope had their own verifier, which checked real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed the envelope.
- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted. The inventory is a client-side app, and no download of it was used this run. "Not consulted" on each card means unchecked, not "no precedent".

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Money.** Costs are shown in South African rand with US dollars in parentheses, at R16.47 = US$1 (US Federal Reserve H.10 release, via FRED series DEXSFUS, 16 October 2026, the latest published on 26 October 2026). Converted figures are rounded.
- **Reader.** No role was given, so the For you section is written for a resident. It was added on 26 October 2026, after this briefing was first sent; its steps come from the verified actions and were checked on the same three tests.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (smoke alarms and fire, heat and oral rehydration, and lining shacks with cardboard or foam) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. The R320 alarm price is such a division, from Overstrand's published total, and is labelled an estimate. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. Several sources returned 403 or 404 (the provincial smoke-alarm page, BusinessTech, and the SAWS site). Each lens had a cap of 10 searches. PubMed was blocked, so Scovronick, Wichmann, and Hess were not re-checked at source. The Western Cape seasonal outlook was not confirmed. The impact region is inferred, not resolved.

References · verification status in brackets

Climate · NOAA CPC, ONI data [confirmed] · WMO seasonal update, OND 2026 [confirmed] · UCT CSAG, "The 'Day Zero' Drought" [confirmed] · Daily Maverick, SAWS outlook, 23 Oct 2026 [confirmed; WC outlook not confirmed] · EWN, dam levels, 14 Oct 2026 [confirmed]

Fire · MEC Bredell, smoke alarms, 24 Oct 2024 [confirmed] · Overstrand, smoke alarms [confirmed] · Swartland, smoke alarms [confirmed] · Pharoah et al. 2022, Wallacedene [confirmed] · ILO, Lumkani and Hollard, Dec 2025 [confirmed; Drakenstein availability unverified] · Cover, Masiphumelele payout [confirmed] · Fire 2022, shack spacing [confirmed] · Stellenbosch, Masiphumelele back-analysis [confirmed] · Stellenbosch University, full-scale test and cardboard linings [confirmed] · Fire Technology 2020, shack tests [results not extracted] · EWN, district R90m, 21 Nov 2025 [confirmed] · EWN, budget "nearly depleted" [confirmed] · George Herald, classification requested [confirmed] · WCG, Paarl Mountain arsonist [confirmed]

Heat · National Heat Health Action Guidelines, 2020 [confirmed] · allAfrica, Cape Winelands heat alerts, Mar 2026 [confirmed] · Naicker et al. 2017 [confirmed] · Scovronick et al. 2018 [not re-checked; PubMed blocked] · Wichmann 2017 [not re-checked] · Hess et al. 2018, Ahmedabad [not re-checked] · SAMRC Gauteng policy brief, 30 Jun 2026 [confirmed, quoted verbatim] · WCG, Norsa Community Centre [confirmed; listing dated 2019] · Kimemia et al. 2020, cool roofs [lens-cited] · EnergyBee, load-shedding suspended [confirmed] · Department of Labour, heat duties [confirmed] · Labour Guide, split shifts [confirmed] · The Citizen, Kakamas [confirmed] · SABC, Kakamas inquiry [confirmed]

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Income and food · Paarl Post, indigent support, 27 May 2026 [confirmed] · TimesLIVE, SRD extended [confirmed] · GroundUp, grants from April 2026 [confirmed] · Grain SA market report, 3 Sep 2026 [confirmed] · Stats SA CPI, Sep 2026 [confirmed] · BusinessDay, grain surplus [confirmed] · Down To Earth, Sihlobo on 2015–16 [lens-cited] · Fin24, maize, Jan 2016 [lens-cited]

Water and finance · TimesLIVE, water to Berg River farms, 2018 [confirmed] · Polity, Feb 2026 drought classification [403; scope unread] · African Union, ARC members [confirmed; SA not listed] · IFRC, Eswatini drought EAP [confirmed] · FRED DEXSFUS exchange rate [confirmed]

Record · Paarl Post, heat record [confirmed] · Paarl Post, Silvertown fire, 2023 [confirmed] · GroundUp, Nether Park, 2017 [lens-cited] · Sowetan, farm fire, Jan 2017 [lens-cited] · News24, Paarl Mountain fires [lens-cited] · News24, Paarl Mountain, Dec 2018 (500 ha) [lens-cited] · Cape Times, Neder Park, 2021 [confirmed] · Paarl Post, Berg River floods, 2023 [lens-cited] · News24, Berg River floods, 2013 [lens-cited] · Bolander, Smartie Town, 2024 [lens-cited] · EWN, Newrest, 360 structures [confirmed] · Cape Argus, Newrest relief [confirmed] · Cape Argus, Thembani, Dec 2025 [confirmed] · EWN, Thembani second fire [lens-cited] · Bolander, May 2026 floods [lens-cited] · Briefly, Noordkamp (Bakka) fire, Oct 2026 [confirmed; single source]

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 26 October 2026 for Paarl, Western Cape. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

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